

1. Another new solar PV array simulator for solar MPPT product design/testing and validation.

2. An environmental chamber for product reliability testing in the temperature range mandated by IEC standards, which is -10°C to 70°C.

3. A high power DC power supply source for high voltage application and other test equipment required for R&D and manufacturing.

4. Automatic test jigs for components, PCBAs and final products.

Q. What are the specific quality parameters that your vendors must adhere to?

A. We have vendor ratings criteria that our quality team checks during vendor audits. Each vendor is evaluated on defined parameters including turnover, processes, equipment/infrastructure and experience. Moreover, vendors must get a pre-defined minimum score in order to be eligible to supply to us.

Q. How do you classify and define the following—potential suppliers, approved suppliers and preferred suppliers?

A. *Potential suppliers* are those who are capable of supplying most of the material we need, on time.

Approved suppliers are those who meet the minimum qualifying criteria defined by us. For instance, a supplier must comply with ISO requirements.

Preferred suppliers are those who can maintain a stock of approved components through regular production and can arrange for material supplies in the case of any urgent requirements, without compromising on quality and while remaining cost competitive. Consistent performance is the key for any preferred supplier. Those who come forward and work like our partners, or get involved in improvements that could lead to enhanced product performance or cost reduction, are always preferred.

Q. Do you have any vendor development programme?

A. We do have vendor development plans. We, at Su-kam, have a team that identifies various vendors and grooms them to meet our requirements if we feel they have the potential to meet our organisational needs.

Q. Do you have any special programmes for 'Made in India' suppliers or MSMEs?

A. We give first preference to 'Made in India' components if they comply with our design and

quality standards. We are working with QCI to train our vendors to ensure that quality systems are in place and also educate them about lean manufacturing, process improvements, 5S and Kaizen techniques.

Q. How do you find a suitable alternative for a failed component?

A. As the market is very competitive, we keep releasing alternate upgraded products at regular intervals to address the issue.

Q. How do you handle a situation in which the component supplier shuts down due to bankruptcy or other business pressures? How do you handle quantities and also after sales support?

A. We have multiple vendors for each and every part, and divide our component quantity requirement between them.

We have an understanding with our suppliers that from Day One, they commit to meeting even low quantity requirements. Periodically, we ensure we give regular orders for other parts; therefore, suppliers rarely refuse to provide us with low volume parts.

Q. What is your back-up plan for when natural calamities occur, creating scarcity of components, which could in turn create a high demand?

A. In situations like these, our design and sourcing teams work together to address this issue very fast and we do have component suppliers from various regions of the world.

Q. What are the environmental regulations such as RoHS that you adhere to, and how does this impact your business?

A. Currently, RoHS is not mandatory in India; yet, we use mostly RoHS-compliant components and material in our products and don't face any major challenge. It will be good if the government also took steps in this direction.

Q. How do you combat suppliers or manufacturers of counterfeit products?

A. We do this by showing customers and sellers our products, and comparing these with those from the grey market, which highlights the disadvantages of spurious products. With regards to components, our quality systems ensure we do not use material or components from unauthorised manufacturers/distributors/dealers or grey market suppliers. □